INTRODUCTION TO

INFORMATION DESIGN

WHAT IS INFORMATION DESIGN?

Simply put, Information Design (ID) is the design of information. However, this definition is too simple to understand what that entails. To fully understand what information design means, you must understand the core principles and competencies that goes into the work of an information designer.



Technical Communication

Information Design is often compared to graphic design. One of the many differences between the two is the technical communication aspect of Information Design.

Technical communication is the ability to take specialized or advanced topics and present them in a way that is simple for someone who is not an expert in the field to understand. Information design is used in many complex fields such as medicine and engineering to provide clarity to the topics.

(Defining Technical Communication)



Visual Design

Visual design aspects of Information Design span beyond the scope of graphic design.

Information Design takes many aspects of visual design into consideration when creating visual design. Things such as font, grouping of like information, number of elements and colour choice are carefully considered in the design process to ensure quality design work.

(Lipton, 2007, pg. 91-950



Human Factors

Human Factors of Information Design include a variety of different things. Information Design is designing *for* the audience.

Information Design takes into consideration the demographic of the audience they are designing for. It requires knowledge about these various factors in the design. Things such as age, culture, gender, and socio-economic factors must be taken into consideration. In addition, Information Design has to take language barriers into consideration to ensure the most widespread comprehension of the design.

(Pettersson, 2010, pg. 171)

AN INFORMATION DESIGNER REQUIRES THE ABILITY TO . . .

Research the Topic

Although this may seem like an obvious trait for any field, it is important that an information designer has a firm understanding of the data and information presented. Having relevant data and facts will strengthen the work being shared.

Be Concise

If a piece has too much words on the medium, it will quickly look cluttered. By being concise, this enables the effective portrayal of the important information to the receivers.

Define the Message

Often times information being depicted has an unclear message. By defining a set message, an information designer is able to ensure that the objective and purpose of the message is being communicated to the audience.

Understand Fonts

By having a deeper knowledge of fonts, an information designer is able to provide better legibility for their work. Poor font choice can make a piece less effective than other fonts, depending on the information being presented.

Use Systems/ Softwares

Information designers must have basic understanding of different systems and softwares and their strengths or weaknesses. Use of certain softwares may be more effective for one piece of work depending on the topic/ outcome.

Provide Simplicity

The end goal of an information designer is to take complex data or information, and make it easier to understand. The argument or information must be simplistic yet compelling at the same time to ensure effective interpretation.

Identify the Audiences

An understanding of the audience being targeted for the work is crucial to understand before designing a piece. By identifying a targeted audience, the work can be modified to better accommodate these individuals.

Understand Colours

Having a common colour scheme throughout the work is essential for effective information design. It prevents the work from looking unprofessional or cluttered. High contrast of colours in text makes it easier to read the information.

Provide Structure

Providing a clear structure will allow for the audience to have greater knowledge, perception, comprehension, experience and understanding.

Understand Mediums

An information designer must be able to identify the best medium for the work and message they are trying to reciprocate to the audience. For an example, an information designer may use different methods for print verses online pieces.

Grab Attention

Although it is important to have informative work, if the work is not visually appealing to grab the audiences attention, it will not be effective in communicating information to the viewer.

Maintain Unity

Sets of information should feel connected, flow effectively as well as have a sense of wholeness. The audience should be able to follow the information in a way that is consistent and efficient.

(Source: Pettersson, 2010)